
Review: The Pleasure of Eliza Lynch by Anne Enright

Published by

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Estimated reading time

3 min

Added on

2025-06-27

Address

<https://www.theguardian.com/books/2002/sep/21/featuresreviews.guardianreview12>

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by Anne Enright

244pp, Jonathan Cape, £12.99

"Francisco Solano Lopez put his penis inside Eliza Lynch on a lovely spring day in Paris in 1854," proudly announces Anne Enright's spectacular new novel. With such an opening - sex, genitals, bold visuals (wonderfully out of kilter with those crinoline times), even a sly nod to the weather - my attention was duly snared. And so is yours. Admit it.

The activities of this intrusive member - "Lopez pushed... and pulled it back again, twenty times in all" - cause a baby to grow inside Eliza. Until then her energies were devoted solely to trying to improve the man's grasp of the French language. But now she carries the heir to all the fortunes of Paraguay.

It isn't as his wife, however, but as his stately, well-cherished mistress that Eliza very soon crosses the Atlantic and sails down the River Parana to an unknown yet enticing future in Asunción. Attended on board by red-haired Dr Stewart and her maid Francine, Eliza struggles to survive the boredom, the sickness and strange appetitive quirks of pregnancy.

And then of course comes the becalming, at which point Enright's novel takes on a distinctly hypnotic, Herzogesque insanity. Her eye for the outlandish detail - whether it's the "tinny discord" from Eliza's piano deep in the hold as they lurch across the Atlantic or the raw madness of humans confined in enclosed spaces - recalls Messrs Aguirre and Fitzcarraldo more than once.

Finally, though, Eliza arrives and settles in Paraguay where, always liberal with her sexual favours, she is detested by the women and adored by the men. She and Lopez engender several more sons and embark on a series of cruel and disastrous wars: that piano crops up again in grim scenes where Eliza faultlessly bashes out "La Palomita" while Lopez calmly dispatches traitors with a pistol.

Meanwhile, the novel leaps mischievously on with barely a backward glance to check you're still on board. In fact, if I'm honest, I wasn't quite. It's not intended to be a very straightforward tale. Facts are thrown at us in the strangest order and we never know much more about its eponymous heroine than that she's Irish, sports golden hair and "liquid" black eyes and does "things in bed a man could scarcely believe". In fact, more than half-way through the novel, Eliza still doesn't feel so much like a person as a collection of brilliantly dashed off observations, arch comments and frayed titbits of Celto-Latin nymphomania.

But then this isn't really a novel about Eliza at all, it's a novel about writing. It's a novel about the most dazzling sort of writing - a collection of pages that will best display Enright's white-knuckle grip on language, her excitable narrative energy, her eye for crunch and colour.

And not only Herzog's claustrophobic films but the magic realism of Gabriel García Márquez also springs to mind. Wouldn't Márquez himself be proud to have written "people found flowers jammed between doors and their lintels, and wreaths floating downstream. Cattle died of secret wounds. Eliza sent the measurements of her own body, by personal courier, to the House of Worth"?

And yes, Enright's descriptions - it's hard at times to tell whether their wealth of detail stems from

research or from her clearly extraordinary imagination - are flawless and absorbing. You read it all with admiration but rarely outright enjoyment. I turned the page because her writerly verve insisted I do so, not because I needed to know what happened next.

In fact it's sobering to realise that, though many writers (myself included) might think they aspire to such a dazzling circus of words, it is, at the end of the day, merely that: very colourful, very sparkly, but something you watch from far away, where anything can happen next and all orchestrated by a ringmaster who has his back to you. *The Pleasure of Eliza Lynch* is first and foremost a performance piece, the (deservedly) winning essay by the most promising pupil in the school. I have no doubt that it's the kind of novel the literary establishment will jump on and garland with prizes.

- Julie Myerson's latest novel is *Laura Blundy* (Fourth Estate)

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